

Architectural styles

CHINESE

For most of its history, Chinese architecture has been entirely tied to Chinese civilization—a common set of beliefs, writing, and aesthetic sensibilities that held sway for thousands of years across a vast area of East Asia.

Chinese architecture has proved influential across East Asia, most notably in Korea and Japan. Although stone and brick are used, it generally relies on timber construction in a post-and-lintel system.

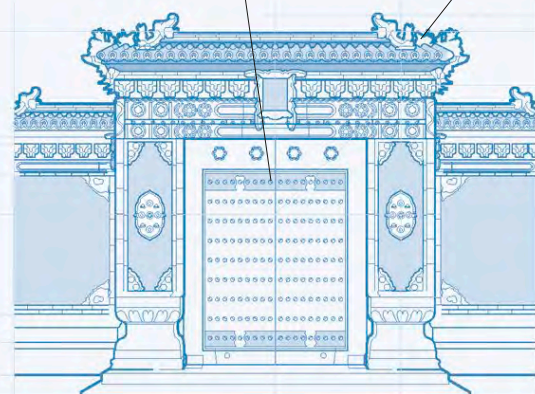
Symmetry is a highly important aspect of Chinese architecture, with many buildings and complexes designed to be symmetrical along two axes. Buildings operate essentially as pavilions, with imperial structures aligned on an axis, and those of lesser importance to the side or in a courtyard. As a result, and despite the obvious importance of the pitched roof, the overall impression is usually horizontal rather than vertical.

With the opening up of the Chinese economy and society in the 1980s, there was an influx of Western styles and building technologies. But today, many architects are looking again at the forms and principles of traditional Chinese architecture.

studs on doors provide extra defensive protection

roof guardians provide symbolic protection

dragon head waterspouts drain terrace of any rain

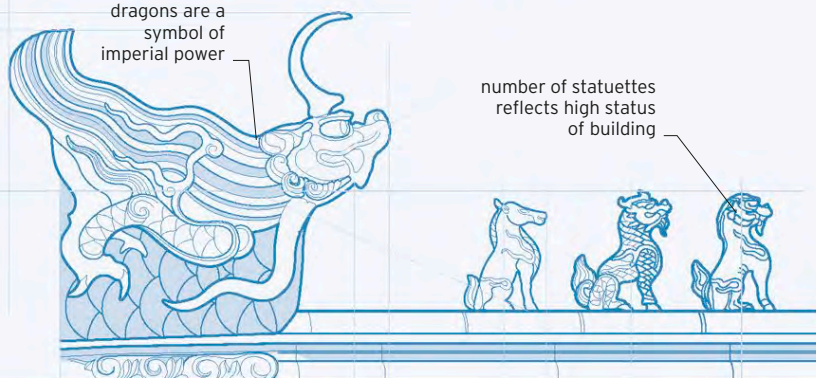


◀ CEREMONIAL GATEWAY

The Forbidden City is separated into precincts accessed by ceremonial gateways marking social and physical boundaries. These range from the Meridian Gate, which is actually five openings topped by buildings with double-tiered roofs, to smaller examples connecting one courtyard to another.

dragons are a symbol of imperial power

number of statuettes reflects high status of building



◀ ROOF GUARDIAN

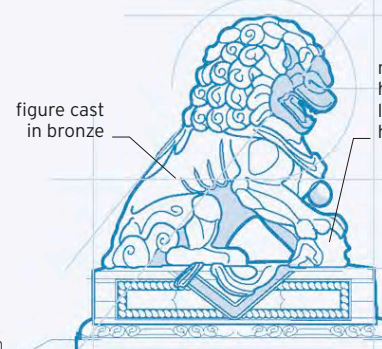
Chinese architecture makes frequent use of the hipped roof form, in which all the sides of the roof slope down to the walls. In imperial architecture, the ridges are typically ornamented with mythical creatures, including the imperial dragon.

▷ LION STATUE

The lion is a common Chinese architectural ornament. Renowned as guardians, lion statues carved from stone were often placed outside notable buildings as a sign of prestige or wealth.

figure cast in bronze

male lion holds a ball (a lioness would hold a cub)



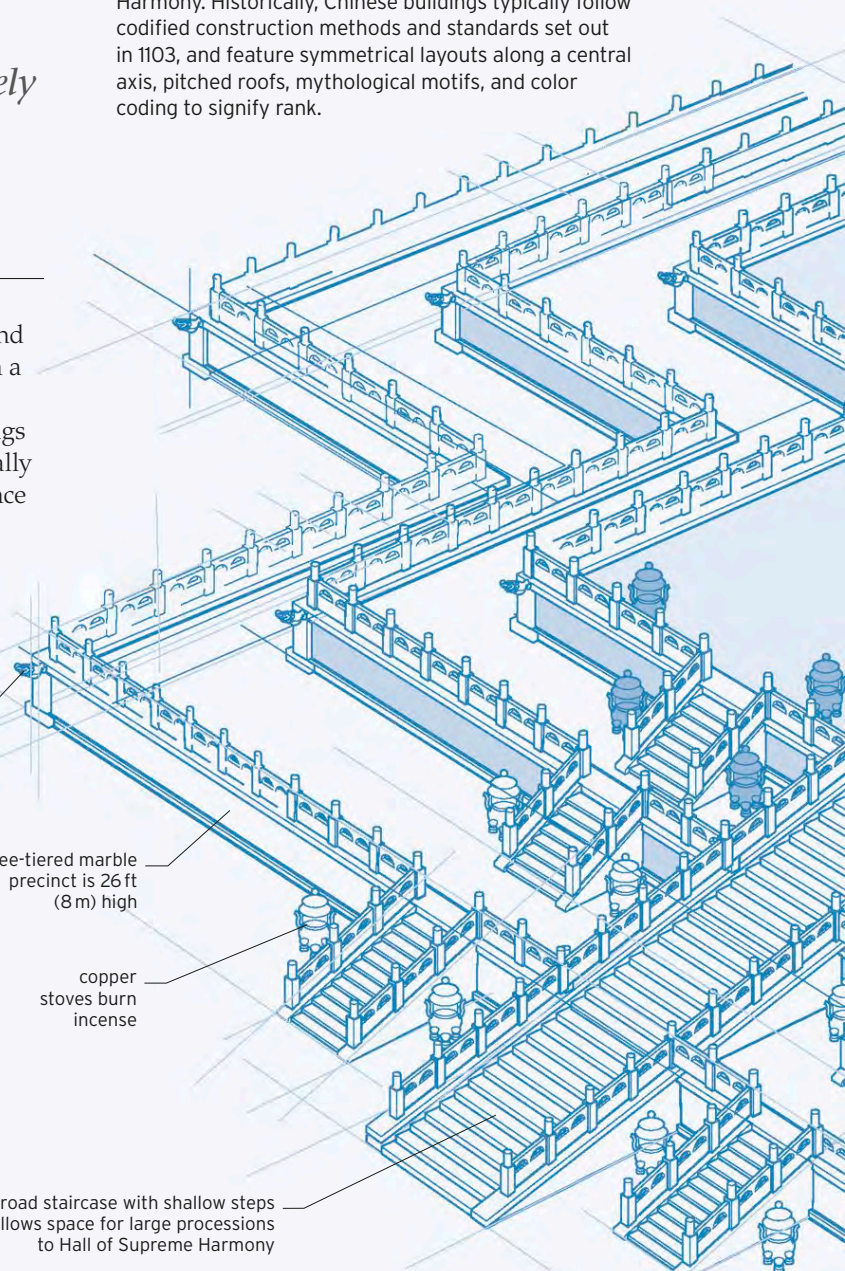
► HALL OF SUPREME HARMONY, FORBIDDEN CITY

Constructed in the Ming dynasty during the early 15th century, the Forbidden City complex (see pp.276-277) contains the emperor's residence, as well as numerous ceremonial spaces, such as the Hall of Supreme Harmony. Historically, Chinese buildings typically follow codified construction methods and standards set out in 1103, and feature symmetrical layouts along a central axis, pitched roofs, mythological motifs, and color coding to signify rank.

three-tiered marble precinct is 26 ft (8 m) high

copper stoves burn incense

broad staircase with shallow steps allows space for large processions to Hall of Supreme Harmony



Beijing was the most populated city in the world from around 1450 until the early 19th century